HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

The Ten Uses of Bitahon: Trusting Hashem in Danger

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Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 4 **This Week:** The Transition from Theory to Practice · The Ten Categories of Bitachon · Two Prerequisites · Category One — Bitachon in Serious (Life-Threatening) Danger

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Recap from Parts 1–3

The Definition

Bitachon = complete reliance on Hakadosh Baruch Hu, the Creator of all, to whose will everything is subservient. Living this brings **security and serenity** (*betach*). We use the intermediaries Hashem created — but place no *reliance* on them.

The Three Categories of Bitachon

Category	Who	Verdict
1	Prophets/exceptional individuals who divested from natural means **by divine instruction**	Not the norm
2	Deniers of providence (Aristotle) / outward affirmers who inwardly trust intermediaries	Wrong
3	The *Yirei Hashem* — recognize Hashem oversees all intermediaries and can change them anytime	The goal

Established Last Time

- Category 3 done properly → **no need to go overboard** in hishtadlut — but also **never laziness** (forbidden)
- **Cause and effect is real, not an illusion** (against the Mutakallimun) — but it's **open to change at any moment** by Hashem's will

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The Turning Point — From Theory to Practice

Now that you've **ולאחר שהבינות ותפסת את כל הדברים האלה, דע כי הביטחון נחלק לכמה וכמה חלקים** *grasped all this [theory], know that bitachon divides into many parts* — regarding what one trusts Hashem *for*, and the outcome sought.

Until now: **theoretical bitachon.** Now: **practical scenarios** — when and how bitachon is actually employed.

A Caveat on the Difficulty

אך הדברים הללו קשים לביאור, וידיעת סודם בשלמות... נשגבת מבינתנו

Understanding precisely how to apply bitachon in every scenario is beyond us — even the prophets couldn't fully grasp God's ways. Asaf said *ואחשבה לדעת זאת, עמל הוא בעיני* ("when I sought to understand this, it was wearying"); Hashem told Moshe *וחנותי את אשר אחון* ("I show favor to whom I show favor"). So Rabbi Avraham offers **general categories and direction**, not an exhaustive system.

The Structure — Five (× Two = Ten) Categories

The Two Master Axes

Axis 1 — Purpose: Bitachon is used either

to *avoid harm/danger*, OR — **להרחקת הנזקים**

to *attain a benefit/goal* — **להשגת התועלת**

Axis 2 — Degree of necessity of the goal/harm:

essential/critical — **הכרחית**

non-essential but nearly so (important) — **בלתי הכרחית אך כמעט הכרחית**

completely non-essential (a luxury) — **בלתי הכרחית לחלוטין**

The Five Categories (הביטחון יפיק כוח עשרה דברים)

#	Category	Physical Example	Spiritual Example
1	Avoiding **serious** harm (הרחקת נזק חמור)	Drowning at sea; life-threatening illness	Pressure to convert / abandon faith
2	Avoiding **non-serious but real** harm	A non-life-threatening but distressing illness	A spiritual discomfort, not critical
3	Attaining an **essential** benefit (תועלת הכרחית)	Basic bread and water to survive	—
4	Attaining an **important but non-essential** benefit	General nutrition (fruit, etc.)	—
5	Attaining a **luxury** (non-essential, non-important)	A pleasant extra	—

Each of the five **× spiritual or physical = TEN** total. E.g., "avoiding serious harm" can be a *physical* serious harm or a *spiritual* serious harm.

Two Prerequisites Before the Categories

Prerequisite 1 — You Cannot Use Bitachon Without Doing Hashem's Will

> *The gateway to* **המבוא לביטחון הוא השמיעה בקול השם יתעלה ודבקות בתורתו והישמר מפני מרידה** *.bitachon is obeying Hashem, cleaving to His Torah, and guarding against rebellion*

There is no point claiming bitachon — however sincere — while not observing the mitzvot. **Doing Hashem's will is the alef-bet prerequisite** for trusting in Him and gaining serenity of mind.

The Supporting Verses (Tehillim)

Verse	Point
בטח בה' ועשה טוב	Trust in Hashem — **and do good** (first)
התענג על ה' ויתן לך משאלות לבך	Delight in Hashem, then He grants your heart's desires
גול על ה' דרכך ובטח עליו והוא יעשה	Cast your way on Hashem — but do the mitzvot
קוה אל ה' ושמור דרכו	Hope in Hashem — **and guard His way**
ותשועת צדיקים מה'... ויושיעם כי חסו בו	He saves them *because they took refuge in Him* (and did His will)

Yirmiyahu's Castigation

אל תבטחו לכם על דברי השקר לאמר: היכל ה' היכל ה' היכל ה' המה

Don't trust the falsehood of "the Temple, the Temple, the Temple" — i.e., *I'll do the three pilgrimages (Pesach, Shavuot, Sukkot) and bring sacrifices, then do as I please all year.* It doesn't work that way:

> *Can you steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, serve* **הגנוב, רצוח, ונאוף... ובאתם ועמדתם לפני?** *?idols — then come stand before Me [in the Temple]*

Only **כי אם היטיב תיטיבו את דרכיכם** — *if you genuinely improve your ways* — will Hashem dwell with you.

This is the obvious-but-essential reminder: there's no practical bitachon without fulfilling Hashem's will.

Prerequisite 2 — Spiritual Bitachon Is Always More "Employable" Than Physical

> **כל ביטחון שתכליתו דתית הרי הוא נכון ושלם מן הביטחון שתכליתו גשמית** **Bitachon for a spiritual purpose is more valid and complete than for a physical purpose** — **even** bitachon for a *non-essential* spiritual .matter outranks bitachon for an *essential* physical matter

The Logic

It makes more sense to employ bitachon **to fulfill Hashem's will** than to employ it for Hashem to fulfill *your* will. Physical bitachon is *for me* — my body, myself. Spiritual bitachon is *for the will of Hashem* — so even a non-critical spiritual aim trumps a critical physical one.

The Analogy — Two People of Bitachon

Person	What They Trust For	Purpose	Verdict
Person 1	Basic survival — bread, clothing, shelter	Purely **mundane** — not to die of hunger/cold, not to beg charity. *Not* in order to serve Hashem or learn Torah	Valid, but lower
Person 2	**Wealth and authority** (non-essential)	**Spiritual** — to give tzedakah, sustain the needy and Torah-scholars (like **Ovadiah**, who hid and fed 100 prophets from Izevel); to use power to restrain the wicked, protect the oppressed, establish justice	**More valid and complete** (יותר נכון ויותר שלם)

(We don't judge Person 1 — someone who can't make ends meet, simply trusting Hashem for food, is in a hard place. But it's not the same level.) (Person 2's intent must be genuine — "you can fool yourself, but you can't fool Hashem.")

The Highest Form — Essential AND Spiritual: Yaakov's Bitachon

אם יהיה אלהים עמדי ושמרני בדרך הזה... ונתן לי לחם לאכל ובגד ללבש... ושבתי בשלום אל בית אבי

Yaakov asked for food, clothing, and safe return — **all essential** — and his purpose was **והיה ה' לי לאלהים** (*"that Hashem be my God"*): so he could be **free to serve Hashem** undistracted by material struggle. **Essential + spiritual = the most praiseworthy bitachon of all.**

The Practical Takeaway — Reframing Changes Everything

A sick person praying *"Hashem, heal me so I won't suffer pain"* → bitachon for a **mundane** matter. The same person praying *"Hashem, heal me so I can keep going to shul, helping the poor, serving You"* → transformed into **spiritual** bitachon.

The shift in focus changes the entire quality of the bitachon. This is why focus matters when employing it.

CATEGORY ONE — Bitachon in Serious (Life-Threatening) Danger

הראשון בהם הוא הרחקת נזק חמור *The first is averting serious harm.*

What Counts as "Serious Harm"

- A **life-threatening illness** (חולאים הקשים)
- **Sudden dangers** (סכנות מקריות) — accident, attack
- War / civil war; falling into **quicksand** (טיט היון); storms, thunder (סופות רעמים); **earthquakes** (רעידת אדמה) — natural forces beyond one's control

These are **critical, death-involved, uncontrollable** situations, for the sake of survival (a mundane purpose).

The Method — How to Employ Bitachon Here

Step 1 — Turn Your Heart to Hashem

שיתלה האדם את לבו בשם יתעלה, ויפתח בו שירחיק ממנו את הנזק ויצילו מן הפגעים — כי כל הסיבות כפופות לחפצו ורצונו all causes are subject to His will.
Cast your heart on Hashem, trusting He will remove the danger and save you — for

Step 2 — Recall Hashem's Promises Through Tehillim

Tehillim 91 (יושב בסתר עליון) — the "song against perils":

- *(Said Shabbat morning, Motzaei Shabbat, and at a levaya — to protect against the spiritual dangers of the soul's ascent.)*
- **Opening** (the structure of trust): **אמר לה' מחסי ומצודתי, אלהי אבטח בו** — "I say to Hashem: my refuge and fortress, my God in whom I trust"
- **Middle**: **כי אתה ה' מחסי, עליון שמת מעונך** — "You, Hashem, are my refuge"
- **End** (the *reason*): **כי בי חשק ואפלטהו, אשגבהו כי ידע שמי** — "Because he desired Me I will rescue him... because he knows My name" — i.e., a **relationship, a brit** with Hashem

Tehillim 18 (David's song when saved from Shaul):

- **Opening** (his love and trust): **ארחמך ה' חזקי, ה' סלעי ומצודתי ומפלטי, צורי אחסה בו**
- **Middle** (*why* he was saved — his righteousness): **כי שמרתי דרכי ה'... כל משפטיו לנגדי... ואהי תמים עמו** — Hashem saved him *because he kept Hashem's ways*

How Tehillim actually works: NOT a mystical/magical effect of reciting the words — but to **remind ourselves who truly governs the world** and to **reset our priorities.** When anxious, open 91, read it (even in English), understand it. *(Anxiety often stems from a lack of bitachon; bitachon can help overcome it — though this is not to say every anxiety sufferer lacks bitachon, nor a substitute for treating genuine medical conditions.)*

Step 3 — Pray (Tefillah)

צריך הבוטח לחזק בטחונו על ידי תפילה ובקשה ותחינה

Verse	Point
מהולל אקרא ה' ומן אויבי אִוָּשֵׁעַ	"I call to Hashem... and am saved from my enemies"
בצר לי אקרא ה'... ישמע מהיכלו קולי	"In my distress I call to Hashem... He hears my voice"
כי מי גוי גדול אשר לו אלהים קרובים אליו	What nation has God so near, *whenever we call* — we are privileged to speak to Hashem
כי תבא מלחמה... והרעתם בחצצרות ונזכרתם... ונושעתם	At war, blow the trumpets, be remembered before Hashem, and be saved

Step 4 — STILL Employ Every Natural Means

מכל מקום ברי כי לשם הרחקת הפגעים הרעים, יש להשתמש באמצעים שתיקן השם יתעלה להרחקתם. Nonetheless — to avert harm, one must use the means Hashem established for averting it.

A sick person must **find the best doctor** (within reason), follow **the best diet** (within reason — not at the expense of Shabbat meals, etc.) — *together with* the trust and prayer above.

The Torah's Own Proofs — Trust AND Act

Even though Hashem is the ultimate cause, the Torah itself commands natural action:

Hashem's Role (verse)	Yet the Torah Commands
"I bring death and life" — **אני אמית ואחיה**	build a parapet so no one falls (Ki Teitzei) — **ועשית מעקה לגגך**
"I wound and I heal" — **מחצתי ואני ארפא**	a doctor shall heal (the license to practice medicine) — **ורפא ירפא**
The Kohen anointed for war says **אל ירך לבבכם... אל תיראו** — trust Hashem, say Shema	Yet **ופקדו שרי צבאות בראש העם** — appoint generals; **ובנית מצור** — build siege-works (employ war tactics)
not by their sword did they" — **כי לא בחרבם ירשו ארץ** inherit the land" (Bnei Korach)	Yet **ויכהו ישראל לפי חרב** — Israel struck Sichon by the sword

The resolution: *"Not by their sword"* means they didn't **rely on the sword alone** — they relied on Hashem's providence (**כי ימינך וזרועך ואור פניך, כי רציתם**) *while* wielding it. **Build balconies, use doctors, raise armies, wield swords — but know the outcome is from Hashem.**

The Snakebite / Cancer Paradigm

if a scorpion stings or a snake bites you (or, *bar minan*, a sudden cancer — **אם קצצך עקרב או הכישך נחש** :diagnosis)

don't *only* lance the wound and take the antidote (do — **לא רק תסרוט את מקום הנשיכה ותגום תריאק** that, certainly!)

but also trust in the One in whose hand is all life — **אלא עליך לבטוח במי שבידו נפש כל חי**

While taking the medicine / undergoing the ' תבטח בה — ובתוך כדי שתיית הצרי ולקיחת התרופה .**procedure — trust in Hashem** that healing comes from Him

This does **not** diminish appreciation for the doctors and medicines — on the contrary, it should **increase** our recognition of how wondrously Hashem created these means.

The Yehi Ratzon Over Medicine (Gemara Berachot, codified in Shulchan Aruch)

May it be Your will, Hashem, that this engagement be for" **יהי רצון מלפניך ה' אלהי שיהא עסק זה לי לרפואה** *my healing." (Rabbi Kada: rarely seen practiced today — seemingly forgotten.)* It **connects the physical act .to the recognition that healing comes from Hashem**

When There Are No Means Left — Pure Bitachon

if you reach a place with no remedy (bitten in the desert with no — **אם תקרה למקום שלא תמצא בו דבר מרפא** :antidote; ill with no hospital) .then **only bitachon remains** — **אז לא נשאר עליך אלא ביטחון בלבד**

The Sailor in the Storm

מי שהפליג ללב ים, וזעף עליו הים, ונתקו פרשיו, ואבדה עצת מנהיגי הספינה וקברניטיה — **לא נשאר אלא ביטחון בלבד**

The sails are torn, the sailors and captain are at a loss (a "Titanic" scenario) — only bitachon remains. **Hashem knows the magnitude of the danger and, in His mercy, can save where all hope is lost** — as He saved **Chananyah, Mishael, and Azaryah** from the furnace, and **Daniel** from the lions' den, *biskhut godel tzidkatam* (in the merit of their great righteousness): **אלהי שלח מלאכה וסגר פום אריותא**.

A sobering note: Rabbi Avraham's own uncle, **Rabbi David (the Rambam's brother), died at sea** — and the Rambam grieved deeply for years. **So bitachon does not always "work" as hoped.** Why? — the next paragraph.

Why the Righteous Sometimes Are Not Saved

ויש עוונות מסתירים ומעכבים חסדו של אלהים — there are sins that conceal and block God's kindness; or **טעם כמוס** — a hidden reason beyond human grasp.

So **ויבא הדבר שהוא ירא ממנו** — the very thing one feared (and trusted Hashem to prevent) sometimes happens.

The Examples

- The **Ten Harugei Malchut** (the ten martyrs, read on Tisha B'Av) — killed by wicked Romans
- **Uriah** killed by Yehoyakim; **Zechariah** killed by Yoash (whose own father had saved Yoash); other prophets killed by wicked Israelites

אין סיבת הדבר קוצר יד ההשגחה — it is **not** because Hashem is unable to save — **אלא סיבות נסתרות בחכמתו** — but hidden reasons in His wisdom, judgments beyond human comprehension.

The Gemara Story — Lulianus and Pappos (Turianus/Trajan)

The wicked Roman ruler **Turianus** seized two righteous Jews (Lulianus and Pappos) and taunted:

"If you are the people of Chananyah, Mishael, and Azaryah — let your God save you from my hand as He saved them from Nebuchadnezzar!"

They answered:

חנניה מישאל ועזריה צדיקים גמורים היו, ונבוכדנצר מלך הגון היה וראוי לעשות נס על ידו — **ואנו נתחייבנו הריגה למקום**" *They were perfectly righteous and Nebuchadnezzar was a worthy king for a miracle. But WE have been found liable for death by Heaven. If you don't kill us, Heaven has many other agents. Hashem has merely handed us to YOUR hand — to exact our blood from you."*

Two Versions of the Ending

- **Our Gemara**: He killed them — but then **officials came from Rome and killed Turianus** (his brain was crushed).
- **The Be'er Avraham's text**: reads that they **were saved in their merit** (שבזכותן ניצולו) — evidently he had a different girsa.

The depth here: their **knowledge of providence**, their **acceptance of Heaven's judgment**, and a **kiddush Hashem they were not even commanded to make.**

A Note on Enemies (Quick Halachic Aside)

When enemies seek your life:

Enemy	When Not Imminently Pursuing	Reasoning
Non-Jewish enemy sworn to kill you	**Strike first** if you have the ability (כמו בימי דוד) — combine bitachon with military action	*(Applied: Israel's neighbors sworn to its destruction — 100% permitted to act first)*
Jewish enemy not actively pursuing	**Do NOT attack** — trust Hashem, escape elsewhere	Like **David**, who twice caught Shaul and spared him

(When someone breaks in actively threatening your life — בא במחתרת — you may kill even a Jewish pursuer to save yourself. The above is about non-imminent enemies.)

The Sage's Answer (Tehillim 37)

Asked whether to get informers/slanderers killed:

> read homiletically: be silent before Hashem, and He will make them into — **דום לה' והתחולל לו חללים** (corpses); pray morning and evening, and — **השכם והערב עליהם בבית המדרש והם כלין מאליהם** .they will perish on their own

Spiritual Enemies — Different Rules

For those who **endanger the faith** — *machtiei harabim* (those who cause the masses to sin), *mosrim* (informers), *apikorsim* (heretics) publicly desecrating Hashem's name — **דינם כדין הגויים**; whoever can eliminate them is praiseworthy (in eras when this applied).

- **If you lack the ability** (e.g., in exile, under hostile government): **only bitachon remains** — pray, and tolerate the situation (יסבול את מצב הדחוק).
- **The Chazon Ish**: *nowadays* we don't act against heretics — that was for eras when Hashem's providence was more revealed.
- **Rav Kook**: today the only way to draw them back is **with love.**

The Beautiful Gemara — Bruria and Rabbi Meir

Rabbi Meir was tormented by *biryonei* (lawless bandits) in his neighborhood and **prayed for them to die.** His wife **Bruria** challenged him:

> Does it say "may *sinners* be consumed"? It says **"sins"!** Look — **מי כתיב "יתמו חוטאים"? "חטאים" כתיב!** and the wicked are no more" — *because they will have* repented. — **אלא בעי רחמי עלייהו דלהדרי בתיובתא** :at the verse's end **pray for them to do teshuvah** (so the wicked are "no — **ורשעים עוד אינם** .more")

Rabbi Meir prayed for their repentance — **and they repented.** *A model of true yirat shamayim.*

Summary

The Framework

- Bitachon now moves **from theory to practice** — but precise application in all scenarios is beyond full human grasp; we work in **general categories**

- **Five categories** (avoid serious harm / avoid lesser harm / attain essential / attain important / attain luxury) **× physical or spiritual = TEN**

Two Prerequisites

1. **No bitachon without doing Hashem's will** (against Yirmiyahu's "Heichal Hashem" falsehood)
2. **Spiritual bitachon always outranks physical** — even non-essential spiritual over essential physical; Yaakov's (essential + spiritual) is the highest; **reframing a request from mundane to spiritual transforms its quality**

Category One — Serious Danger

1. **Turn your heart to Hashem** (all causes are subject to His will)
2. **Recall His promises** through Tehillim 91 and 18 — to *reset priorities*, not as magic
3. **Pray** (tefillah, tachanun)
4. **Use every natural means** — best doctor, diet, tactics — the Torah itself commands parapets, doctors, armies, swords, *while* trusting Hashem
5. The **Yehi Ratzon** over medicine connects the act to Hashem
6. When **no means remain** — pure bitachon (Chananyah/Mishael/Azaryah; Daniel) — though **it doesn't always "work"** (the Rambam's brother at sea; the martyrs), for **hidden reasons** beyond human grasp (Lulianus & Pappos)
7. **Enemies**: strike first against a non-Jewish enemy if able; spare a non-pursuing Jewish enemy; for spiritual enemies, act only where able and where they can't be returned — otherwise pray (Bruria: pray for the *sins* to end, not the sinners)

Coming Up Next Week

- When may one **rely on miracles** (the final aspect of Category One)?
- **Spiritual** serious danger (Category One, spiritual side)
- Then **Category Two** — bitachon for important-but-non-critical matters

(Schedule: Rambam tomorrow evening — thrones; Hilchot Shabbat Thursday — new chapter. Aiming to finish Perek 8 before Tisha B'Av.)

B'Ezrat Hashem

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